



THE STAR ATTRACTION: With Modi as the only issue, the entire election is centred around him

such bravura performance, with no trace of exhaustion in his voice or on his face.) Tonight, he keeps the best lines for Sonia-ben. He is entitled to his rejoinder. The previous day in the Saurashtrian town of Jasden, a Congress citadel, Sonia Gandhi was airdropped to the welcoming slogan of "Gujarat ka naksha badal denge". Heavily protected and kept at a safe distance from *aam admi*, she didn't kiss the ground on landing. Once on the stage, she, reading out from a prepared text, invoked Gandhi, Patel and Nehru, and told them why she was there: for the liberation of Gujarat. "They talk *vikas*, they do *naash*." Who's raging against terrorism, and who "released terrorists from the jail and took them to Afghanistan?" she asks. "BJP did it". The best line of her speech writer, though, was: "They talk Gandhi and Patel and act Godse."

Modi doesn't require someone else to do the work for him. "Narendrabhai" has been doing it all alone, without even taking a "one-hour vacation" all these five years. Sonia-ben has earned his wrath. And he is enjoying it as much as the crowd.

The offensive runs like this. "So, Soniabehn calls me merchant of death. Ha Ha. Who is supporting the merchants of death? It can't be me. Those who revoked POTA are the guardians of the merchants of death, who will have no sanctuary in Gujarat.

Sohrabuddin...Sohrabuddin...Sohrabuddin...encounter...encounter...encounter...let them go on chanting. Sohrabuddins won't be worshipped in Gujarat. He was killed in Gujarat. And let Soniabehn answer, who's protecting Afzal Guru, who has already been convicted by the Supreme Court? Soniabehn is throwing mud at me, and I don't know whether it comes from Italy or India. But I know one thing. Lotus blooms in mud. You vote lotus, I'll give you Lakshmi. And whatever happened to the slogan of *chak de Gujarat*. Did they know what *chak de* meant? Unlikely. They must have thought it was an Italian phrase...." It is not that he has nothing beyond Soniabehn. He has mythology, development (he tries hard to make it less boring) and national security, all appropriately marinated in Hindutva. Take the Ram Setu (Adam's Bridge) in the Palk Strait, on which the Congress blundered by denying Ram his place in the Hindu faith. "Did Ram marry Sita?" The crowd answers, "yes." "Did they go for *van vas*?" "Yes." "Was

MIND THE GAP

BJP vote share increased sharply after the 2002 riots, but slid in 2004

ASSEMBLY

	1999	Votes (%)	MLAs
	BJP	44.8	117
	Congress	34.9	55

2002	Votes (%)	MLAs
BJP	49.9	127
 Congress	39.2	51

LOK SABHA

	1999	Votes (%)	MPs
	BJP	52.5	20
	Congress	45.4	7

2004	Votes (%)	MPs
 BJP	47.4	14
 Congress	43.9	12